

Google, YouTube, and Wikipedia didn't exist. But even if those resources were available, I wouldn't have known how to use them; I wouldn't have been sure what to study next. Instead, I learned how to write *Hello, world!* programs in different programming languages but still felt I wasn't making real progress. I didn't know how to move beyond the basics.

There's so much more to software development than loops and functions. But once you've completed a beginner course or read an introductory programming book, your search for more guidance leads to yet another *Hello, world!* tutorial. Programmers often call this period the *desert of despair*: the time you spend wandering aimlessly through different learning materials, feeling like you're not improving. You become too advanced for beginner materials but too inexperienced to tackle more complex topics.

Those in this desert experience a strong sense of impostor syndrome. You don't feel like a "real" programmer or know how to craft code the way "real" programmers do. I wrote this book to address this audience. If you've learned the basics of Python, this book should help you become a more capable software developer and lose this sense of despair.